China

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E.O. 11652, Sec. 3(E) and 5(D) or (E)
OSD letter, May 3, 1972
By ..., NARS Date 6-24-75

WAR DEPARTMENT
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF OF STAFF
WASHINGTON, D. C.

3 September 1945

MEMORANDUM FOR THE PRESIDENT:

SUBJECT: United States Commitment for Equipment of the Chinese Army.

In accordance with a request from Commodore Vardaman to Colonel Pasco concerning the alleged U.S. commitment to furnish equipment for (120) 90 Chinese divisions, the following information is submitted.

The War Department accepted a plan for equipping and training thirty Chinese divisions in early 1942 and included the equipment in the Army Supply Program. This plan was submitted by General Stilwell in accordance with his directive to strengthen the Chinese Army thru the media of Lend-Lease and training aid.

Training of a second group of thirty divisions was approved by the War Department in January 1943. Commitment was not made as to the provision of equipment for these second thirty divisions with the exception that ten per cent thereof was approved for training purposes.

At a Joint Chiefs of Staff Meeting at the Cairo Conference (November 1943), General Stilwell reported that Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek had a plan which called for the equipping of three groups of thirty divisions each or a total of ninety divisions. The following extract from the minutes of the 130th JCS Meeting at the above conference is the only indication the War Department has of a commitment, if any, President Roosevelt made to Generalissimo Chiang Kai-shek:

> GENERAL MARSHALL said the President had already been spoken to about the arming of the third group of Chinese divisions. The President had postponed any definite commitment in this connection although he had made it clear that the United States intends eventually to provide the equipment for this group. Therefore there was no question that in the end the United States will arm the Chinese group but the question was as to when this could be done. He thought that this provided a possible basis for a statement by the Generalissimo. If the Generalissimo could say that he had been assured by the President that the United States would arm and equip the entire Chinese Army and omit any mention of the specific time at which this would be

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done it was possible that the people of China would feel that China's participation in the conference had been successful, while the U.S. would be spared an untimely commitment.

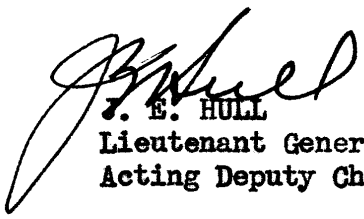
General Wedemeyer has recently informed the War Department that no record of any commitment for U.S. support of ninety divisions exists at Headquarters, U.S. Forces China Theater. He stated, however, that the Generalissimo has stated that President Roosevelt promised to equip ninety Chinese divisions in the presence of Harry Hopkins at the Cairo conference.

War Department action on furnishing equipment to the Chinese Army consisted of approval of the first thirty divisions plus ten per cent of the second thirty divisions as outlined above until March 1945 at which time approval was extended to a total of thirty-nine divisions for the purpose of carrying out specific operations as agreed between the Generalissimo and General Wedemeyer.

The basis for the 120 division figure now being used by the Chinese may be as follows. Both General Stilwell and General Wedemeyer have repeatedly urged the Generalissimo to take steps to reduce the number of divisions of the Chinese Army to a figure which China could reasonably expect to support. To this end the Generalissimo has agreed to reduce the number of Chinese divisions from 348 to a total of 120 by 1 July 1946.

A survey of the equipment program for the 39 U.S. sponsored Chinese Divisions as of VJ-Day revealed that approximately one-third of the equipment had been handed over in China to the Chinese Government, one-third was in the India-Burma and China Theaters but not yet turned over to the Chinese and one-fifth was en route between the United States and Asia ports. Practically all of the remainder of the program has been assigned to China by the Munitions Assignments Board but not yet shipped from the United States.

FOR THE CHIEF OF STAFF:



J. E. HULL
Lieutenant General, GSC
Acting Deputy Chief of Staff

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